

December

15

2009

Clever octopus

Scientists in Indonesia reported seeing a veined octopus picking up coconut shells from the ocean bed and fitting them together to build a hideaway home. This was the first known example of an invertebrate (animal with no backbone) using tools in nature.



Also on this day

1612 German astronomer **Simon Marius** was the first to use a telescope to view the Andromeda galaxy (a system of millions of stars). Marius thought he was looking at a cloud of dust and gas within our own galaxy.

1929 Swiss pilot **Walter Mittelholzer** became the first to fly over Mount Kilimanjaro, the tallest mountain in Africa.

2011 The seven-year **Iraq War** ended when the USA announced the completion of its military mission in Iraq.

Born this day

37 CE Nero, Roman emperor. A cruel and ruthless ruler, he was rumoured to have caused the Great Fire of Rome, which left two-thirds of the city in ashes.

1832 **Gustave Eiffel**, French engineer. His most famous design is the Eiffel Tower in Paris, France.

1903 Ice-cream cups

Italian food vendor Italo Marchiony received the patent for his ice-cream cup machine, a moulding kit that created small pastry cups with handles for holding the sweet treat.



1989

Mount Redoubt

Ash from volcanic clouds spewed forth by the eruption of Mount Redoubt in Alaska, USA, caused an aircraft's engines to fail. The plane landed safely, but as a result of this event, the Alaska Volcano Observatory began closely monitoring volcanic activity in the region.

